

2021

Cybersecurity
INSIDERS

REMOTE WORKFORCE SECURITY REPORT



axiaad

OVERVIEW

Securing the remote workforce has become a critical priority for organizations affected by the closing of offices and workplaces in the wake of the ongoing COVID-19 pandemic.

This 2021 Remote Workforce Security Report reveals the state of securing the new workforce. The report explores key challenges and unique security threats faced by organizations, technology gaps and preferences, investment priorities, and more.

Key findings include:

- Phishing threats (71%) and malware (61%) have emerged as the most significant new threat vectors concerning remote work environments.
- The top three policies and protocols that employees are most resistant to complying with include multi-factor authentication (35%), mobile device management (33%), and password managers (26%), making it difficult for them to be fully and securely authenticated to all of their applications, devices, etc.
- Seventy-eight percent of organizations agree that it is critical to very important for security tools to adapt to a changing digital environment and that people should not have to configure them.
- Almost half of all organizations (45%) are shifting from multiple, siloed security tools to a platform solution.

We would like to thank [Axiad](#) for supporting this important research. We hope you find this report informative and helpful as you continue your efforts in protecting your organization against evolving threats and during challenging times.

Thank you,

Holger Schulze



Holger Schulze

CEO and Founder
Cybersecurity Insiders

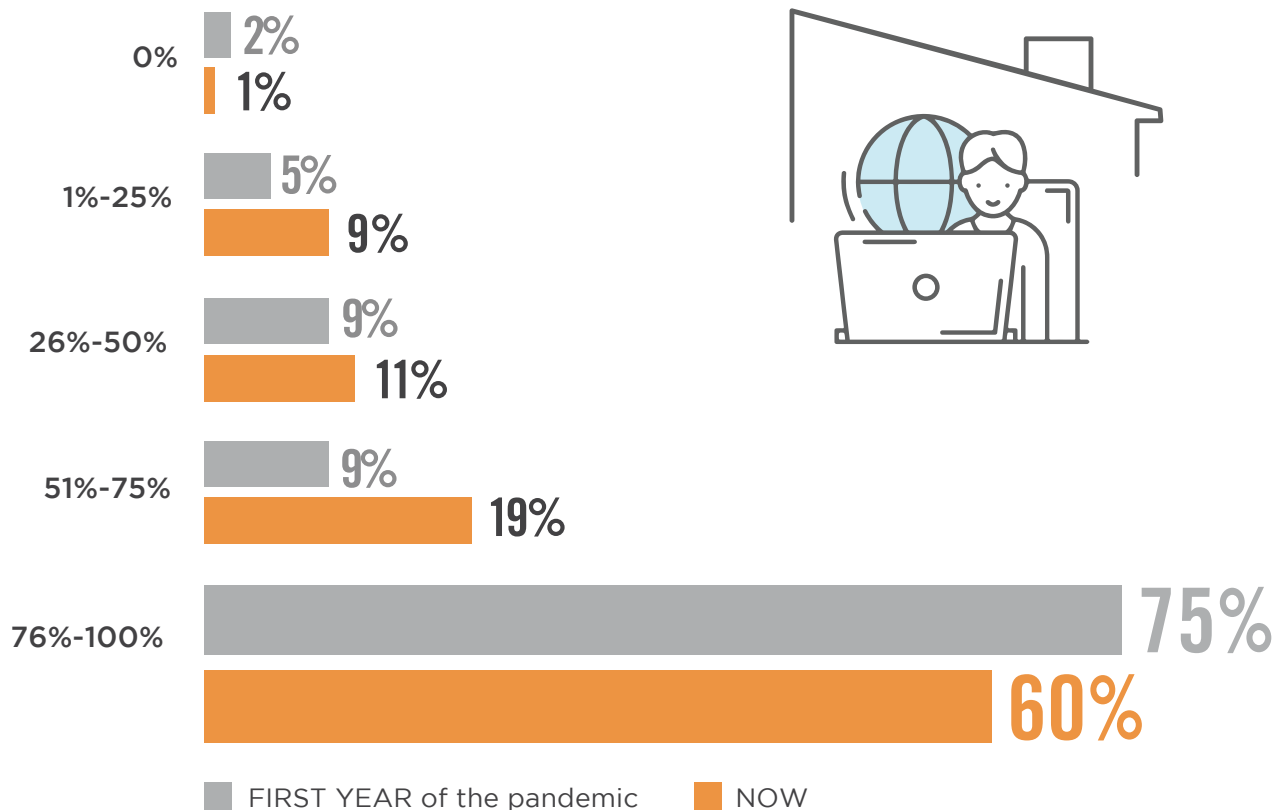
Cybersecurity
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DRAMATIC INCREASE IN REMOTE WORKFORCE

In the first year of the COVID-19 pandemic, a majority of organizations made the shift to a remote workforce for almost all employees with 75% of companies having more than 75% of their employees working from home. A year later with the end of the pandemic in sight for some, 60% of organizations still have over 75% of their workforce remote. We expect a good portion of the current remote workforce to permanently stay remote.

► What percentage of your workforce is working remotely/at home **NOW** during the COVID pandemic?

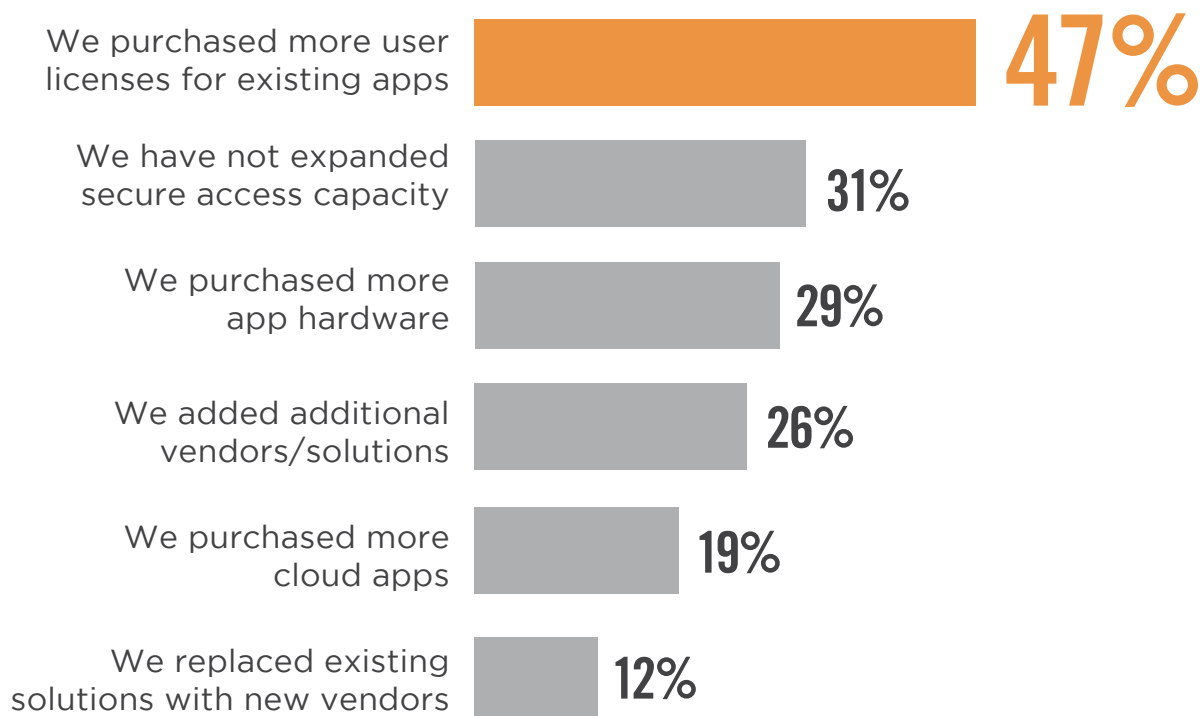
Share of employees
working remotely



WORKFORCE EXPANSION PATHS

To bolster the capacity for providing employees with secure access to corporate resources, organizations purchased more user licenses for existing applications (47%), more hardware (29%), added additional vendors (26%), and purchased more cloud applications (19%). Thirty-one percent of organization did not expand secure access capacity.

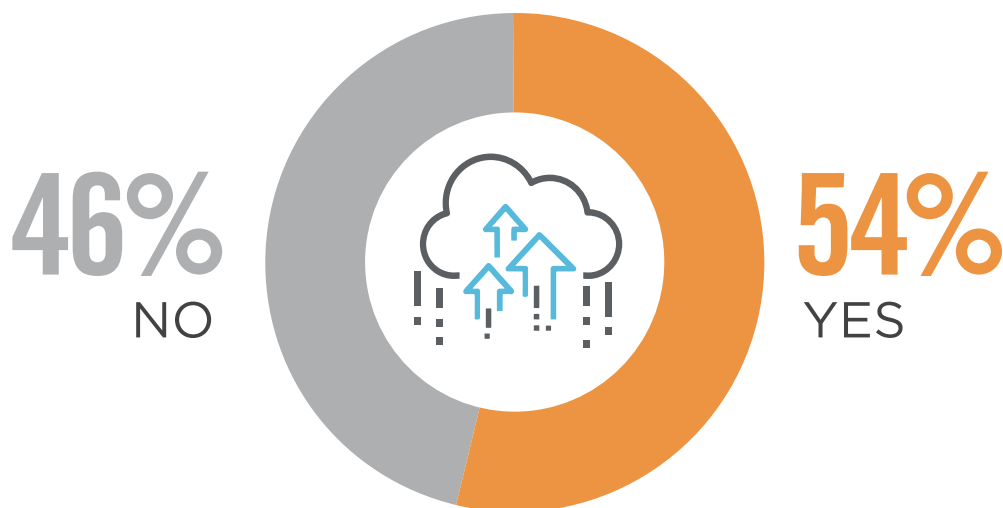
▶ How did you expand your capacity for providing remote employees with secure access to corporate resources?



MIGRATION TO CLOUD

The majority of respondents (54%) are accelerating their move to cloud-based applications. However, despite transitioning to a cloud environment, and the advantages it offers for an integrated security solution, organizations have not transitioned their security controls. Seventy-nine percent of security professionals enforce the same level of security controls and data management for all roles when accessing corporate resources remotely.

- ▶ **Has COVID accelerated migration of additional user workflows or applications to cloud-based applications?**



- ▶ **Do you enforce the same level of security controls and data management for all roles in the company as they access remotely?**



THREAT VECTORS

Phishing threats (71%) and malware (61%) have emerged as the most significant new threat vectors concerning remote work environments.

► What specific threat vectors are you most concerned about with employees working from home?



71%

Phishing



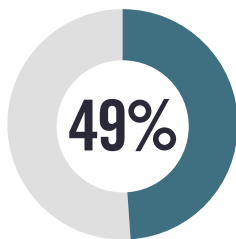
61%

Malware

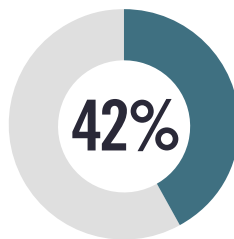


56%

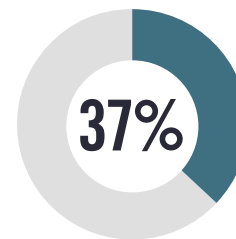
Unpatched systems/
vulnerability exploits



Unauthorized users/
privileged access



Malicious
websites



Identity
theft

Account takeover 24% | Insider attacks 22% | Other 2%

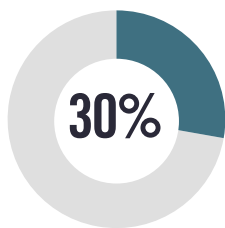
SECURITY SUPPORT ISSUES

Since moving to working remotely, there has been an increase in phishing attempts reported by 66% of security professionals. This is followed by reports of malware on devices (30%) and concerns over connecting personal devices (29%). For 61% of respondents, remote workers have impacted their helpdesk wait times. These increases in attack attempts and wait times are challenging security professionals, taking time and IT resources away from strategic projects that can be costly to an organization. Having to wait longer for help is also having a detrimental effect on productivity of remote workers.

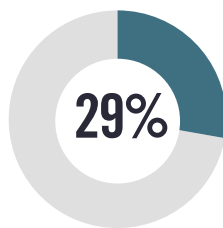
► Since going remote, which of the following have you received increased security support questions about?



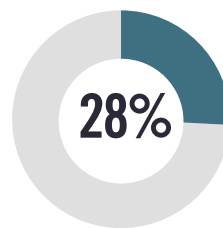
66% reported phishing attempts



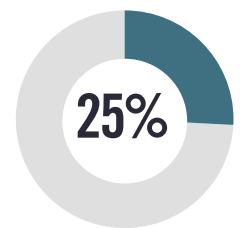
Reports of malware on devices



Concerns over connecting personal IoT to same internet network used for work



Suspicious two-factor authentication attempts



Unable to share/back-up from certain device types

Reporting breaches of third-party tools 24% | Concerns about terms of service of certain apps 16% | Other 6%

► Has remote work impacted your helpdesk wait times?



YES

61%

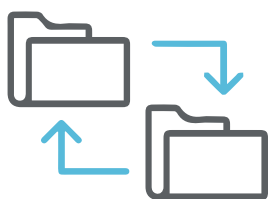
39%

NO

RISKY APPS

When asked what work applications cybersecurity professionals are most concerned about, they mentioned file sharing (65%) and email and messaging apps (60%). These application concerns are followed by websites (40%), social media (36%), video conferencing (31%), and free business web apps (30%).

▶ What work applications used by remote workers are you most concerned about from a security perspective?



65%

File sharing



60%

Email and messaging



40%

Websites



36%

Social media



31%

Video conferencing



30%

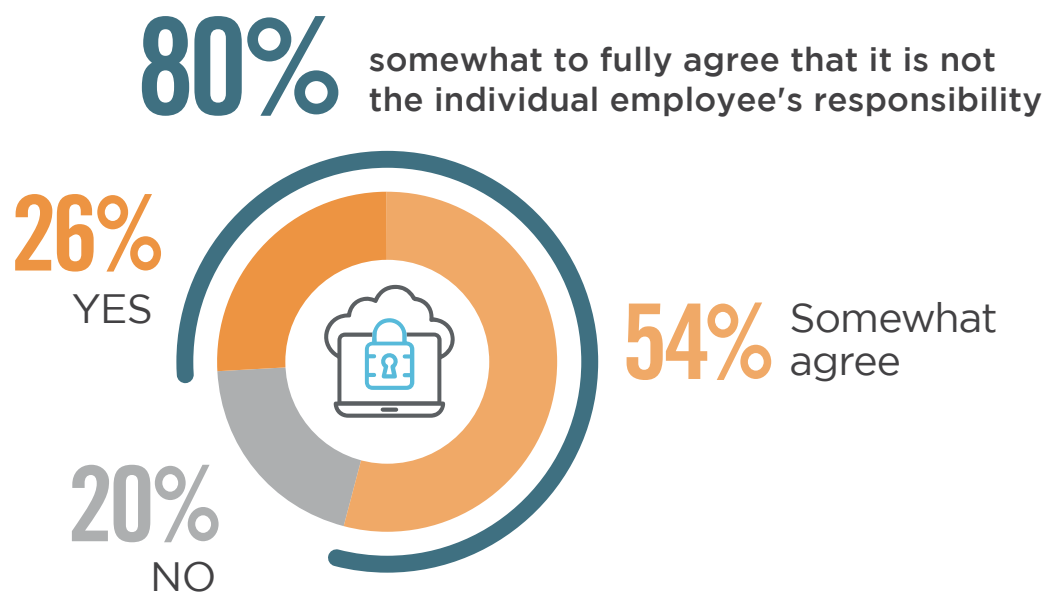
Free business web applications

Subscribed, corporate managed web applications 12% | Other 2%

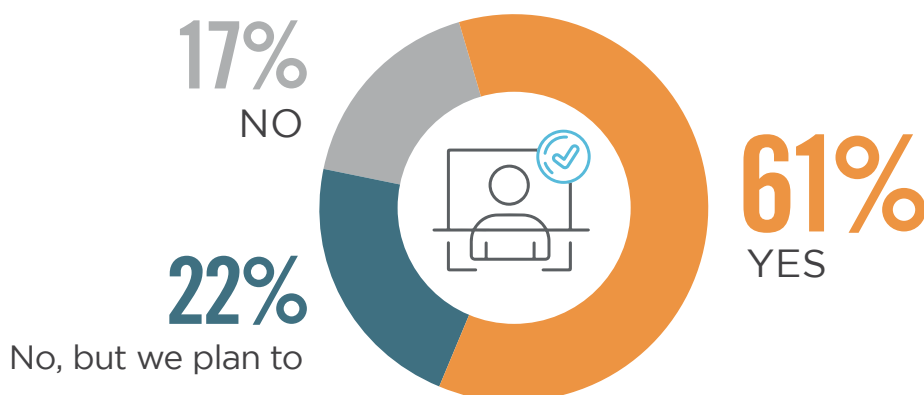
SHIFTING SECURITY BURDEN

Almost half of all organizations (45%) are shifting from multiple, siloed security tools to a platform solution. When asked about the shift in the burden of securing the remote workplace, 80% of professionals somewhat (54%) to fully agree (26%) that it is not the individual employee's responsibility. Sixty-one percent of organizations have an identity proofing/verification process before issuing users with identity credentials. Twenty-two percent of professionals don't have a process, but plan to. As the burden moves to the employees, companies need to prioritize verifying each employees' identity so they can trust who is on their network.

- ▶ **Do you agree with the following statement: Much of the burden of responsibility for securing the remote workplace is shifting from the IT security team to the individual employee.**



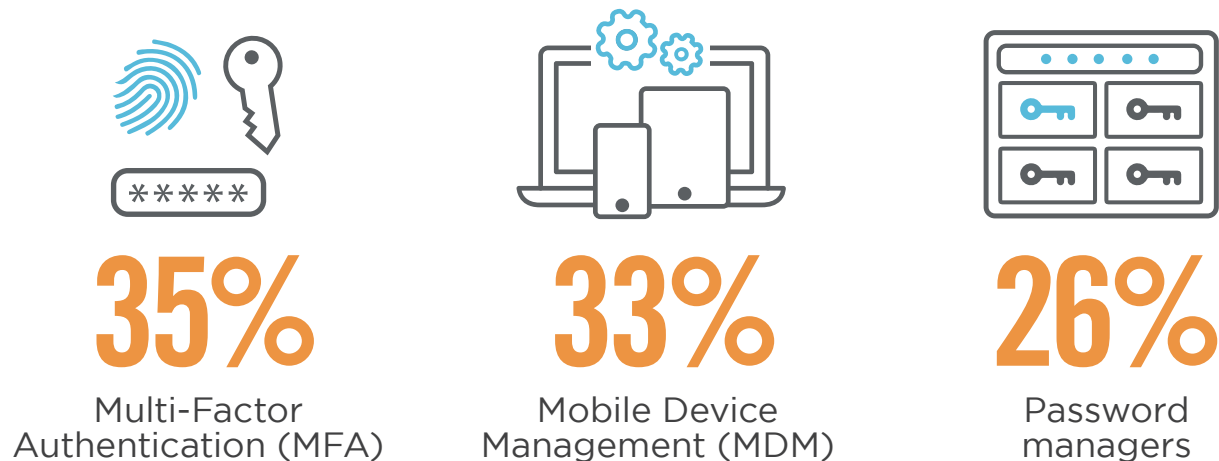
- ▶ **Do you currently have an identity proofing/verification process before issuing users with identity credentials?**



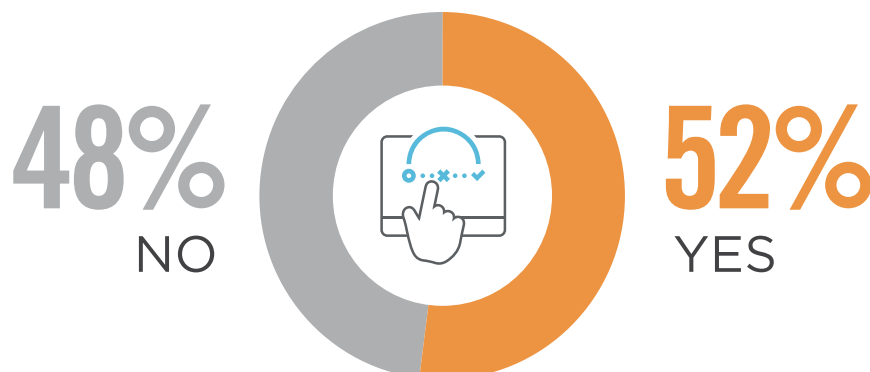
ADHERENCE TO SECURITY POLICIES AND PROTOCOLS

The top three policies and protocols that employees are most resistant to complying with, and instead find workarounds over half the time, include Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA) (35%), Mobile Device Management (MDM) (33%), and password managers (26%), making it difficult for them to be fully and securely authenticated to all of their applications, devices, etc. This means that even if a company has invested in strong authentication technology like MFA, they are still at risk unless they can encourage employees to comply with their policy. This is even more challenging with a remote or hybrid workforce, as employees are not in the office to work with their IT team to deploy and utilize new technologies. Fifty-two percent of security professionals have experienced employees finding workarounds to corporate security systems and policies.

▶ Which of the following security protocols are individuals most resistant to adhering to or maintain?



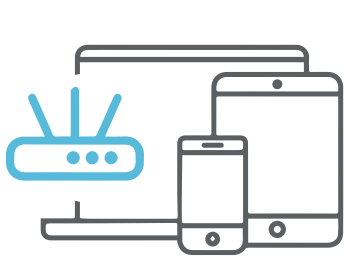
▶ Have you experienced employees finding workarounds in your security system/policies?



BARRIERS TO SECURING REMOTE WORK

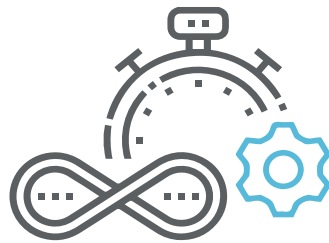
When asked about the biggest impediments to scaling security for remote workforces, organizations named remote work equipment (40%), bandwidth restrictions (39%), and logistics of installing agents on personal devices (27%) as the key barriers. Bandwidth issues emphasize that remote work is significantly impacting productivity. As a result, IT's bandwidth is more focused on assisting users than on strategic projects.

► What have been the biggest impediments to scaling security for your remote workforce?



40%

Equipment for remote work
(devices, cameras, accessories, etc.)



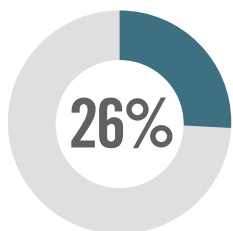
39%

Bandwidth restrictions impacting productivity

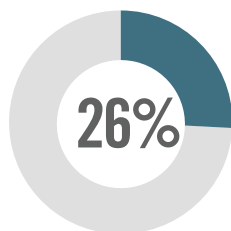


27%

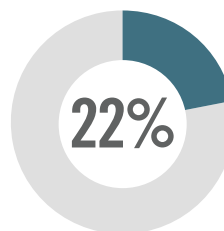
Logistics of installing agents on employees' personal devices



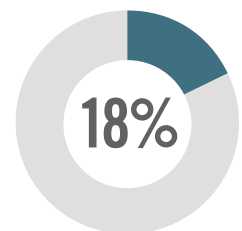
We have not experienced security scaling issues



Not enough security staff



Monetary requirements for buying more or better security appliances



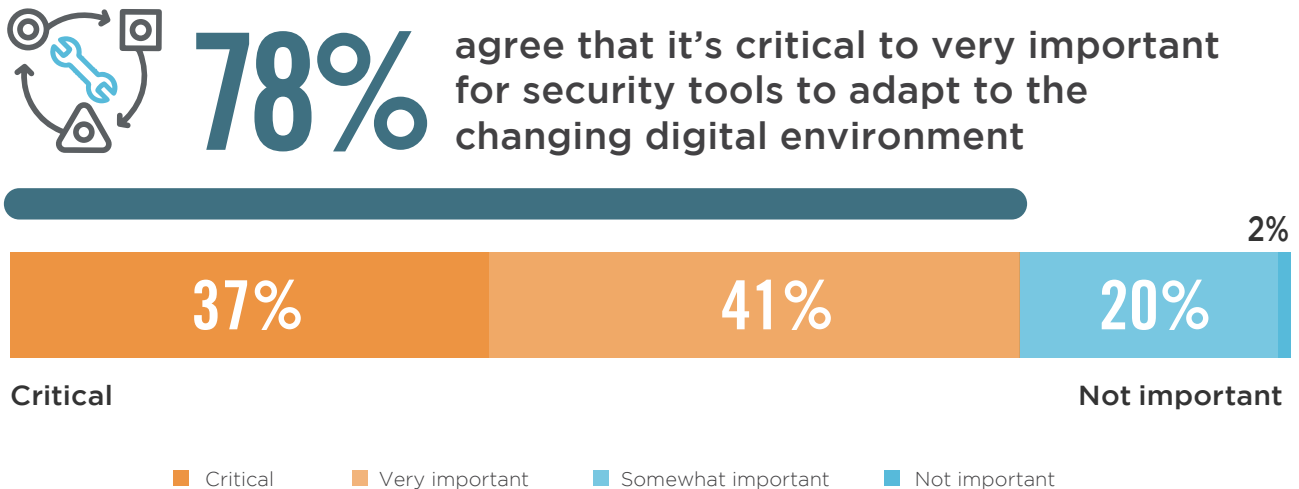
Not enough licenses

Not enough security budget 17% | The logistical challenge of installing more or better security appliances 16% | Increase in helpdesk calls 1% | Other 4%

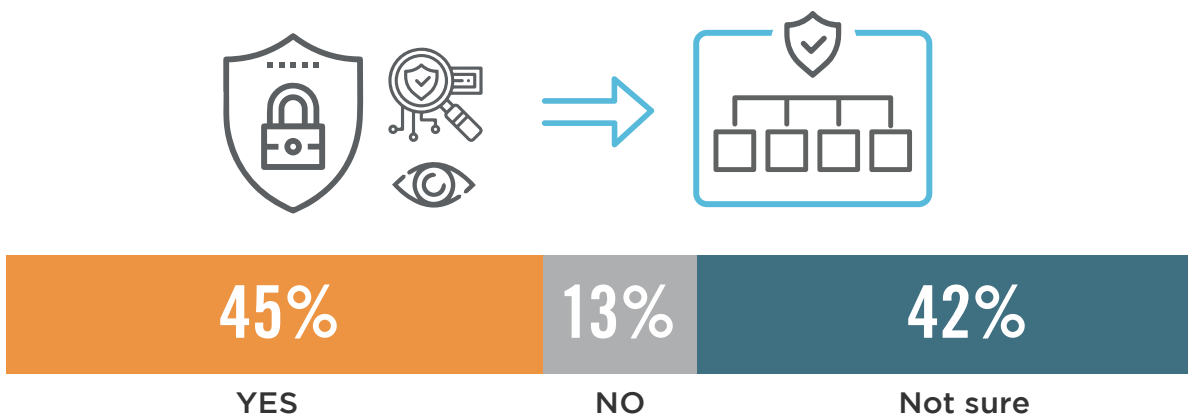
SECURITY TOOLS ADAPTING TO CHANGING ENVIRONMENTS

Due to the limited bandwidth of IT teams, 78% of organizations are looking for adaptable tools that people won't have to configure. Tools that can be integrated on a platform solution instead of managed in silos are also increasing in popularity, likely for the same reason. As noted by almost half of the respondents (45%), IT teams are looking for ways to simplify the day-to-day maintenance of their various security solutions, which streamlined platform solutions accomplish.

- **How important is it that security tools can adapt to changing digital environments, without requiring humans to configure them?**



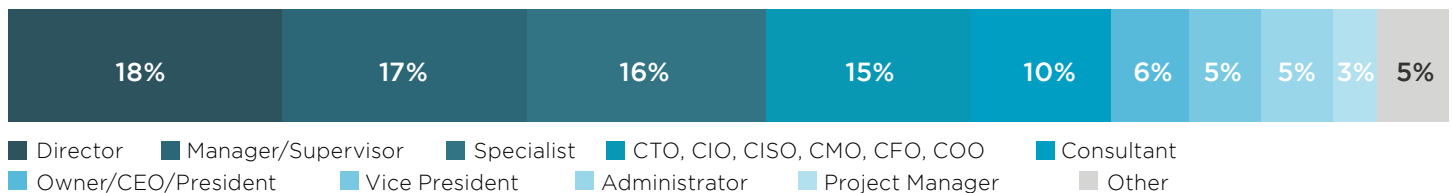
- **Going forward, do you expect your organization to shift from multiple, siloed security tools, in favor of platform solutions that cover the entire digital infrastructure?**



METHODOLOGY & DEMOGRAPHICS

This report is based on the results of a comprehensive online survey of 317 IT and cybersecurity professionals in the US, conducted in May 2021, to identify the latest enterprise adoption trends, challenges, gaps, and solution preferences for remote work security. The respondents range from technical executives to IT security practitioners, representing a balanced cross-section of organizations of varying sizes across multiple industries.

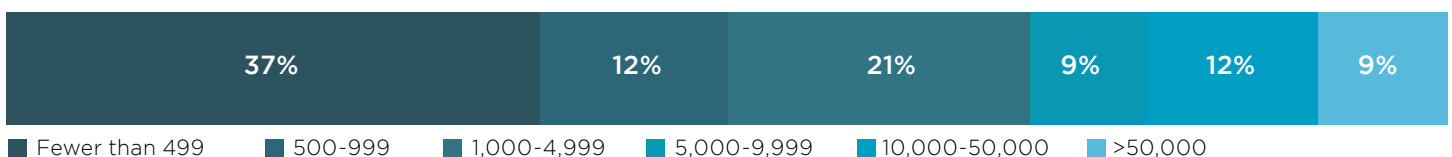
CAREER LEVEL



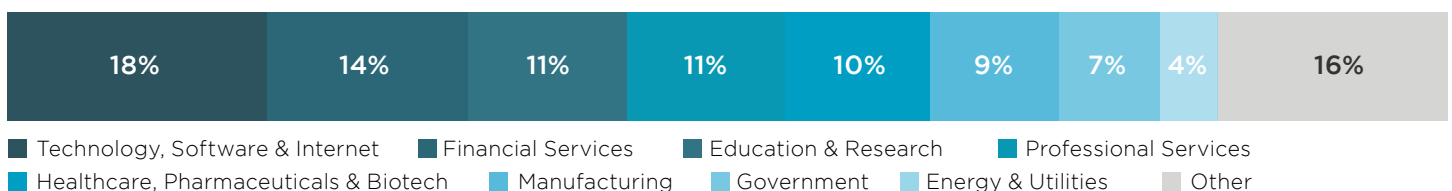
DEPARTMENT



COMPANY SIZE



INDUSTRY





Axiad provides enterprises with its SMARTidentity solution to deliver complete trust across the identity spectrum. Whether you need to secure your employee access, their online interactions, or your machines and devices, SMARTidentity ensures zero trust with PKI, MFA, and FIDO in one platform – Axiad Cloud. Businesses can take an identity-first strategy to cohesively deploy and manage all their credentials such as certificates, mobile MFA, TPM, hardware tokens such as YubiKeys, smart cards, and biometrics.

Axiad makes the journey to passwordless simple with user-centric solutions for credential issuance, lifecycle management, and emergency access from anywhere. The SMARTidentity solution is trusted by Fortune 500 companies across healthcare, aerospace & defense, energy & oil, transportation, finance, and more.

For more information visit www.axiad.com.